

Deciding whether to pay someone to do the chore you hate

8 findings · 13-step checklist · 1 myth · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

Paying to be rid of a chore you dread carries a **real payoff** in how you feel. The guilt isn't about laziness; it shows up even when a service you've never met does the task.

THE GOAL

You're deciding whether this trade is fair, not whether you've earned it. Write down the exact price you were quoted, in plain numbers.

CHECKLIST

You've just found out what it would cost to pay someone for this chore, and you're deciding whether to go ahead.

- ☐ Write down the exact price you were quoted for the chore, in plain numbers.
- ☐ If the price feels off, check one more provider's rate before you decide.
- ☐ If you're figuring out your exact hourly rate to justify this, stop: compare it to a subscription you already pay without thought.
- ☐ Name who would be doing the task: a specific person you know, or a service you've never met.
- ☐ If the person who'd do it is someone you know, decide whether to book an anonymous service instead.
- ☐ If you're going with a service, send a normal, businesslike message, no apology for the request.
- ☐ Name the specific week you're waiting for things to calm down before doing this yourself.
- ☐ Check your calendar from the last time you told yourself the same thing, and note honestly whether that week stayed clear.
- ☐ If the week you're waiting for turns out just as busy, that's your answer: stop waiting for a free calendar to appear on its own.
- ☐ If you decide to do it yourself instead, put a specific day and time on your calendar this week.
- ☐ If you decide to pay, open the booking or message while the price is still in front of you.
- ☐ **Confirm or pay** before you close this out: a yes you don't act on today reopens the same decision next time.
- ☐ Write down the day or the booking, the price, and your reason, somewhere you'll see it again.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** The guilt isn't about laziness. It shows up as soon as you picture anyone, even a service you've never met, actually doing the task for you.
- 2** Paying someone to do a chore you dread carries a **real happiness payoff**: about as much as an actual raise.
- 3** Don't calculate your exact hourly rate to justify paying. Putting a precise price on your own time is what **makes it feel scarce**.

The guilt, sorted from the task

KNOW

The guilt isn't about laziness. It shows up as soon as you picture anyone, even a service you've never met, actually doing the task for you.

People who mentioned any provider completing the task felt more guilt than people who never pictured a provider at all. [Source 1](#)

DO

Picture the job as paid work you're giving someone. That reframe is what lowers the guilt enough to act.

In an advertising test, seeing the purchase as a benefit to the provider left people less guilty and more willing to buy the service. [Source 1](#)

What paying for it actually buys you

KNOW

Paying someone to do a chore you dread carries a **real happiness payoff**: about as much as an actual raise.

The happiness link held up across several countries and at every income level, including people without much extra money. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

What lifted people's mood after paying for the chore was feeling less time pressure, measured the same evening.

People's mood improved because their measured stress about time dropped; the study never checked how the chore turned out. [Source 3](#)

DON'T

Don't spend all the newly freed time solo if you share your home. The relationship boost shows up specifically when that saved time turns into shared time.

The relationship study found that boost depended on the freed time turning into shared time together, measured across several couples. [Source 4](#)

The math tricks working against you

KNOW

Waiting for things to calm down is a bias, not a plan. A day two weeks off looks just as free as any other, until it arrives.

The same illusion doesn't show up nearly as much for money, so the far-off day isn't the safe bet it looks like. [Source 5](#)

DO

Check this week's real calendar before you decide instead of trusting the lighter week you're picturing further out.

People consistently misjudge a future day as free until it gets close, while judgments about future money don't show the same bias. [Source 5](#)

DON'T

Don't calculate your exact hourly rate to justify paying. Putting a precise price on your own time is what **makes it feel scarce**.

A test that had people bill an identical task at a higher rate left them more time-pressured than billing it at a lower rate. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Paying someone to do a chore you hate only makes sense once you're already well-off; everyone else should just grit their teeth and do it themselves.

ACTUALLY

The same large study tested this directly and ruled out income as the explanation. If anything, in the US data, **the tie to life satisfaction ran a bit stronger for people with less money**, not more. [Source 3](#)

Sources

1. <https://pdfs.semanticscholar.org/9453/df71a486daa8e17df1d67d30c92f2e115c73.pdf>
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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Time and feeling rushed at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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